



Get App store refund

...if you (or your kid) have made accidental in-app purchases from the Apple store, that is. Here's how <http://dgit.in/1hkEKis>



Glass on the battlefield

The U.S. Airforce is beta-testing Google Glass for use in situations that require quick decisions during combat and intelligence missions <http://dgit.in/PUoVER>

smartphone – by means of a setting in the firmware that's specified by the manufacturer. This setting, called the Power Platform Role, tells Windows what type of device it's running on, and Windows adjusts itself accordingly. If you're using a desktop, for instance, Windows will automatically boot to the desktop, skipping the Start screen entirely. (This, and all other defaults can be changed by the user). That's one setting less for someone who's setting up a new Windows 8 machine. Similarly, the Search and Power icons on the Start screen aren't universal – their presence depends on the size of the screen, and is a privilege reserved only for devices with generous amounts of screen real estate. Smaller tablets won't see the setting, but larger tablets and laptops/desktops, will. The improved behaviour of Windows 8 apps shows just how much thought Microsoft has put into this update. For instance, only apps started with a mouse or a keyboard will have the Windows taskbar/title bar integration. If an app is started with a touch gesture, (even on a touchscreen laptop) it won't sport this feature, as the system assumes you're using the device as a tablet rather than a PC.

The annoying Hot Corners feature has been fixed in Windows 8.1 Update 1, which introduces a small (but significant) delay on mouseover before popping up the Charms menu.

Windows 8.1 Update 1 is, without doubt, the best iteration of Windows 8 so far, improving the operating system on nearly all fronts. The only area that could use some attention is the Start menu, but Microsoft is rumoured to be working on a Start menu replacement for its next update.



A handy disk usage analyser shows you what's taking up space

8 Changes in Windows 8.1 Update 1

- 1 Access the taskbar from anywhere**
The taskbar now auto-hides when you're running a Windows 8 app that's been started using a keyboard/mouse. This allows quick access to your open apps, the time, Wi-Fi signal strength and your battery-level, among other things.
- 2 Minimise/close full screen Windows 8 apps**
Similarly, an auto-hidden title bar means that Windows 8 apps can be minimised or closed with ease, as opposed to guessing the right mouse gesture in Windows 8/8.1.
- 3 Pin Windows 8 apps to the desktop taskbar**
Windows 8 apps are now more desktop-friendly, and can be pinned to the taskbar alongside regular Windows programs.
- 4 Boot to desktop – by default**
Windows will now directly boot to the desktop on PCs and laptops, skipping the Start screen entirely. If you'd rather have it the old way, you can change this setting.
- 5 Right-click menu on Start screen**
Right-clicking on a tile on the Start screen now gives you the option of pinning it to the Start screen or taskbar, or even completely uninstalling it. We can't believe this feature didn't exist earlier!
- 6 Be notified about app installations**
It's small details like this one that show how much effort Microsoft is really putting into improving Windows 8's usability. Earlier, installing a new app or program would automatically add it to the Start screen, which would lead to the Start screen getting cluttered pretty quickly. That doesn't seem to be the case anymore though, as a subtle notification informs the user of any newly installed apps with a link to the app drawer.
- 7 Find Power and Search buttons easily**
We're not sure why this wasn't always the case with Windows 8, but the Start screen finally shows a Power and a Search button – so, no more fiddling around with the mouse trying find the correct pixel that will shut down your PC. The visibility of these buttons depends on the size and type of your device – smaller tablets and phones won't show them, while bigger devices like laptops and desktops will.
- 8 Decrease app size**
Another subtle improvement, the size of the app icons in the app drawer can now be decreased, allowing a greater number of apps to fit on the screen.

For now, one of the many Start menu replacements such as Start 8 or Classic Shell will do just fine. The better desktop integration for Windows 8 apps vis-a-vis the auto-hidden taskbar and title bar is a great step towards making Windows 8 apps more visible and accessible for desktop users. So far, the Windows 8 Store has been all but neglected by desktop users, but we're hoping this update will change that and encourage developers to make better apps, now that they have a wider audience.

Should you upgrade?

The big question is, of course – should you update? The answer's slightly complicated. If you're perfectly happy

with your Windows 7 setup and don't want to go through the hassle of reinstalling your apps and reconfiguring your settings, there's no need to update (particularly if your business has critical applications that depend on Windows 7 and would require extensive testing/rewriting to ensure compatibility). Windows 7 will be supported until at least 2016, by which time Windows 9 should be out. If, however, you were previously on the fence about the upgrade, we say go for it. Windows 8 has finally reached a point where most of the annoying niggles have been ironed out. It's also generally snappier than Windows 7 running on the same hardware, so there's no real reason to hold back. **1**